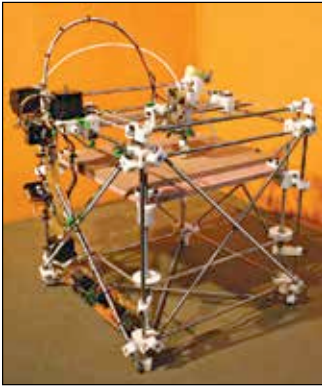




Technology for the Masses

from the University of Bath, RepRap aimed to give the common man access to the world of 3D printing. With the ability to manufacture its own parts, the RepRap was a pioneer when it came to the field of DIY 3D printing.

In less than a year, in 2006, the SLS or Selective Layered Sintering style of 3D printing comes of age and while the costs are still high, with viability snapping at their heels and the ability to print from a variety of substances including glass, carbon fibre and substances of different varieties based on application. In January 2014, the patent keeping SLS printing away from being used by others expired opening a whole range of possibilities.

Fast forward two more years to 2008 and the same organization that aimed to bring 3D printing to the masses developed a new model- the RepRap Darwin which becomes the first self-replicating 3D printer as a majority of its parts are made of plastic and can be 3D printed.

While 3D printed organs are slowly becoming a reality, 2008 also saw major breakthroughs in 3D printed prosthetics. Scott Summit developed an artificial limb complete with a thigh, knee, shin and foot all made as a single piece requiring no assemble opening up new avenues in the field of 3D printed prosthetics. Scott went on to start Bespoke Innovations, a company that manufactures custom fairings for prosthetic limbs in 2009.

2009 also marked the year of Makerbot, a start up that allowed users to build and assemble their own 3D printers are home at a fraction of the cost of commercial printers. With the support from Makerbot, Richard Van As from South Africa who had lost fingers in his left hand to a carpentry accident collaborated with a Ivan



The ability to change lives